

Honestly? ChatGPT wrote this macro.

It renames 200 files in about four seconds. I didn't type a character of it — and I still read every line before I ran it.

```
Sub RenameWithDate()  
...  
Here's exactly how, so you can too.
```

I don't type the syntax.

01

Describe

Say what the job is, in plain words.

02

Read

Go through what came back, line by line.

03

Check

Prove it is safe before it runs on anything real.

That's the whole skill. It takes an afternoon to learn, and it doesn't expire when the next model ships.

200 files, all named wrong.

BEFORE

report final.xlsx

report final v2.xlsx

report FINAL ok.xlsx

AFTER

2026-03-04_report.xlsx

2026-03-11_report.xlsx

2026-03-18_report.xlsx

The kind of job nobody puts on a CV, and everybody does.

40 min

BY HAND

4 sec

BY MACRO

The prompt, word for word.

```
Write an Excel VBA macro.  
It loops through every .xlsx file in a  
folder I choose, and renames each one  
to YYYY-MM-DD_<original name>, using  
the file's last-modified date.
```

```
Ask me anything unclear before you  
write the code.
```

That last line is the one people skip. It makes the model ask instead of guess — and guessing is where bad code comes from.

Eleven lines. That's the whole thing.

```
Sub RenameWithDate()  
Dim f As String, p As String  
p = "C:\Reports\  
f = Dir(p & "*.xlsx")  
Do While f <> ""  
Name p & f As p & Format( _  
FileDateTime(p & f), "yyyy-mm-dd") _  
& "_" & f  
f = Dir  
Loop  
End Sub
```

I didn't write a character of it. I read every line of it. Those are not the same thing, and only one of them is optional.

What does it actually touch?



11 LINES

THE ONLY LINE THAT WRITES

```
Name p & f As p &  
Format(...)
```

Find every line that writes, moves or deletes something. There is exactly one. If I can't point at it and say what it does, I don't run the macro.

Run it on a copy. Every single time.

The real folder

Untouched. Always.

A copy of it

This is where the macro runs.

Duplicate the folder. Run it on the duplicate. Look at the result before you go anywhere near the real one.

VBA has no undo. That isn't a warning about AI. That's just VBA.

What if it stops halfway?



97 FILES RENAMED

THEN IT STOPPED

So I ask before I run it: what happens if a file is already open, or the new name already exists? A macro that dies at file 97 leaves you worse off than one you never started.

Ask what happens when it fails.
Not if.

What I never paste into it.

Client or company names

Anything copied off a work drive

The data that lives inside the files

The macro doesn't need to know what's inside your files to rename them. Neither does the model.

If you can't paste it, describe it.
A description is enough to get code.

The code isn't the skill.

Asking well and checking properly is. That's the part that doesn't get automated — the typing was never the job.

THE SAME METHOD WORKS WITH

ChatGPT

Copilot

Gemini

Claude

**What's the 40-minute job you
still do by hand?**

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